POLISH WINGED CAVALRY

The Polish army of the 17th century was predominantly a cavalry force – horsemen outnumbered foot soldiers by three or four to one, the reverse of the proportions found in other European armies. The army's elite force was the winged cavalry, or *hussaria*. Originally light skirmishing horsemen in the manner of the Hungarian hussars, by the 17th century they had evolved into a shock force of heavy cavalry.

Service in the *hussaria* offered prestige and privileges that attracted volunteers from the cream of the Polish aristocracy. The cavalryman not only had to provide his own powerful horses, he also had to equip himself with a full panoply of armour and weapons, including a cuirass and *zischagge* helmet, an armour-piercing sabre known as an *estoc*, a pair of pistols, and probably a long *czekan* war hammer. The only equipment supplied by the state was the *hussaria*'s key arm, the *kopia* – a long hollow wooden lance with a steel tip.

A *hussaria* regiment was altogether a strange and imposing sight. Many of the cavalrymen wore gilded wooden "wings", decorated with eagle feathers, upon their backs. They also decked themselves in cloaks of leopard or tiger skin and hung long silk streamers on their lances. When they charged, the feathers and the streamers emitted a sinister hissing sound that reportedly had a psychological impact upon their enemies.

The practical effectiveness of the *hussaria* on the battlefield was demonstrated on many occasions. Operating in regiments of around 300 riders, they would charge at accelerating speed, opening and closing their ranks as they rode in order to evade musket fire. Their lances, which could outreach an infantry pike, were expected to shatter on impact. They would nonetheless serve to break up the defensive formations of the enemy's pikemen. The sabres and war hammers would come into use once the enemy was exposed; no armour was proof against them. Despite their armour and large mounts, the *hussaria* retained the speed and flexibility of their hussar origins, often making repeated charges that showed an ability to regroup and manoeuvre en masse unequalled by any other cavalry of the day.

Victories attributable to the Polish winged cavalry range from the crushing of the Swedes and Russians at the battle of Klushino in 1610 to the historic defeat of the Ottoman Turks outside Vienna in 1683 under Jan Sobieski.

> "NO SOONER DOES A HUSSAR LOWER HIS LANCE THAN A TURK IS IMPALED ON THE SPIKE."
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> **WESPAZJAN KOCHOWSKI** DESCRIBING A CHARGE BY THE POLISH CAVALRY IN *THE SONG OF VIENNA LIBERATED*, 1684



Winged cavalry squadron
Today's Polish cavalry recreates the astonishing spectacle of 17th-century *hussaria* with their formidable lances and curious "wings" attached to the backplates of their armour. They were the pride of the Polish army, defending the country from attacks by the Russians, the Swedish, the Ottomans, and marauding Cossack bands.